

Overview: Explicit Modelling (I Do, We Do, You Do)

Explicit modelling breaks learning into three clear phases: "I Do" where the teacher demonstrates while thinking aloud, "We Do" where teacher and pupil practise together with guided support, and "You Do" where the pupil works independently with help available. This gradual release of responsibility ensures pupils see exactly what success looks like before attempting tasks alone, dramatically reducing confusion and building confidence.

When to Use This Strategy

- Pupil asks "What do I do?" immediately after instructions
- Work looks completely different from what you demonstrated verbally
- Pupil waits for peers to start, then copies their approach
- Makes the same mistakes repeatedly despite corrections
- Freezes when faced with new types of problems

Step-by-Step Guide

1 Plan your "I Do" demonstration

Before the lesson, work through the task yourself. Note the decisions you make, the steps you take, and any tricky points. Plan exactly what you'll say during your think-aloud.

Tip: Write down your think-aloud script for the first few times. It's harder than it looks.

2 Deliver "I Do" with think-aloud

Demonstrate the task while verbalising every thought. Narrate your decisions, your checking, your reasoning. Pupils watch and listen—no participation yet.

Teacher says: "Watch me do this first. I'm going to talk through everything I'm thinking. Your job is just to watch and listen."

Tip: Go slower than feels natural. What's obvious to you isn't obvious to them.

3 Check understanding before "We Do"

Ask a quick question to check they followed. "What did I do first? Why did I check that?" Don't move on if they can't answer.

Teacher says: "Before we try together, tell me: what was the first thing I did?"

4 Guide through "We Do" together

Do another example together. Ask them to tell you what comes next, but you're still in control. They're contributing, you're guiding. Share the cognitive load.

Teacher says: "Now we'll do one together. You tell me what to do next, and I'll write it. What's our first step?"

Tip: If they get stuck, model that bit again. Don't just tell them—show them.

5 Transition to "You Do" with support

Move them to independent work, but stay close. Let them know help is available. Watch for early errors and intervene quickly.

Teacher says: "Now it's your turn. I'll be right here if you get stuck. Start with step one—what is it?"

Tip: Position yourself to see their work. Catch errors early, before they become habits.

6 Adjust phase length as needed

Some pupils need longer "I Do" with multiple examples. Some need extended "We Do" before going solo. Some can shorten "We Do" if "I Do" was clear. Watch and adapt.

Tip: There's no fixed ratio. Match the phases to the pupil and the complexity of the task.

English Example: Writing a topic sentence for a paragraph

Year 9 working on essay writing. Pupil working at KS2 level needs to write topic sentences but doesn't know where to start.

I Do: Model with think-aloud

Teacher: Display paragraph question: "Why is Lady Macbeth a powerful character?" Think aloud: "Right, my topic sentence needs to answer this question directly. I'm going to start with 'Lady Macbeth is powerful because...' That way my reader knows exactly what this paragraph is about. Let me write: Lady Macbeth is powerful because she controls Macbeth's actions."

Pupil: Watches and listens. Sees the teacher's thinking process.

Check understanding

Teacher: Ask: "What did I do first? Why did I start with 'Lady Macbeth is powerful because'?"

Pupil: Responds: "You answered the question directly."

We Do: Guide together

Teacher: New question: "Why is Macbeth an ambitious character?" Say: "Now let's do one together. What should we start with to answer this question directly?"

Pupil: Says: "Macbeth is ambitious because..." Teacher writes it. Together they complete: "Macbeth is ambitious because he wants to become king."

You Do: Independent with support

Teacher: New question: "Why is the witches' prophecy important?" Say: "Your turn. Write a topic sentence that answers this question directly. I'm right here."

Pupil: Writes: "The witches' prophecy is important because..." Teacher monitors and prompts if needed.

Maths Example: Solving two-step equations

Year 8 learning to solve equations like $2x + 3 = 11$. Pupil working at KS2 level needs explicit demonstration of the process.

I Do: Model with think-aloud

Teacher: Write $2x + 5 = 13$ on board. Think aloud: "My goal is to get x on its own. I need to undo the operations. I see $+5$, so I'll do the opposite—subtract 5 from both sides. 13 minus 5 is 8, so now I have $2x = 8$. Still not alone— x is being multiplied by 2. Opposite of multiply is divide. 8 divided by 2 is 4. So $x = 4$. Let me check: 2 times 4 is 8, plus 5 is 13. Yes!"

Pupil: Watches each step. Hears the reasoning behind each decision.

Check understanding

Teacher: Ask: "What did I do first? Why did I subtract 5?"

Pupil: Responds: "Because there was $+5$ and you needed to undo it."

We Do: Guide together

Teacher: Write $3x + 2 = 14$. Say: "Your turn to guide me. What should I do first to get x on its own?" Pupil says subtract 2. Teacher writes it, asks: "Now what?" Continue together.

Pupil: Directs each step while teacher writes. Gets to $x = 4$. Checks together.

You Do: Independent with support

Teacher: Write $4x + 1 = 17$. Say: "Now solve this one yourself. I'll watch. Talk me through it as you go if you want."

Pupil: Works through the problem. Teacher observes, prompts if stuck: "What operation do you see? What's the opposite?"

Science Example: Drawing a labelled diagram of a cell

Year 7 learning to draw and label plant cells. Pupil working at KS1 level needs to see the process modelled before attempting independently.

I Do: Model with think-aloud

Teacher: Draw on board while talking: "First I'm drawing a rectangle for the cell wall—it's the outside, so I draw it first. Now inside that, I'm drawing another rectangle close to the edge—that's the cell membrane, it's just inside the wall. Now a big oval in the middle—that's the vacuole, it takes up most of the space. Small circle near the edge—that's the nucleus. Now I'm adding labels with ruler-straight lines. Each line touches the part and points to the label."

Pupil: Watches the sequence. Sees which part is drawn first, second, third.

Check understanding

Teacher: Ask: "What did I draw first? Why did I draw the cell wall before the other parts?"

Pupil: Responds: "Because it's on the outside."

We Do: Guide together

Teacher: Give pupil paper. Say: "Let's draw one together. I'll draw on the board, you draw on your paper. What do we draw first?" Pupil says cell wall. Both draw it. Continue step by step together.

Pupil: Draws each part as teacher draws it on board. Checks their drawing matches.

You Do: Independent with support

Teacher: Say: "Now draw another one without me drawing at the same time. You can look at our first one if you need a reminder. I'll watch."

Pupil: Draws cell independently. Teacher observes, reminds of sequence if pupil gets stuck: "What comes after the membrane?"